

Photo & Biometric Specifications Guide

Exact photo requirements by country - one of the most common, and most avoidable, reasons applications get sent back.

2026 UPDATE — this replaces outdated advice you may have read elsewhere

Photo specifications are updated periodically by each government - always verify the current size, background, and format against the official visa application guide for your destination before printing anything. The figures below are the standard specifications most commonly published, but treat them as a starting point, not a final source.

Country	Typical Size	Background	Notes
USA	2 x 2 inches	White	Taken within the last 6 months
UK	35 x 45 mm	Light grey or cream	Neutral expression, no shadows
Canada	35 x 45 mm	White	Two identical copies typically required
Australia	35 x 45 mm	White or light-colored	Submitted digitally with your online application
Germany	35 x 45 mm (biometric)	Light grey	Must meet ICAO biometric photo standard

Common Photo Mistakes That Cause Delays

- Using an old photo instead of one taken within the required timeframe
- Wrong background color for the specific destination
- Wearing glasses, a hat, or an expression not permitted under the guidelines
- Photo printed at the wrong size or resolution
- Digital photo file exceeding the upload size limit for online applications

Practical tip

Get your photos taken at a studio after you've confirmed your destination's exact specification, not before. Bring the printed specification sheet with you and ask the studio to match it precisely.